

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Existentialism - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 32 diagnostics, 14 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Existentialism - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Existentialism learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Existentialism (Kierkegaard, Sartre, Heidegger): Existence and Essence; Choice, Responsibility and Authentic Existence; Being-in-the-world and Temporality* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 10. □ The paper prints "Sarte"; the philosopher is **Jean-Paul Sartre**. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper I. **Terminology and citation rule:** the English concept leads and the source term follows immediately in parentheses - *the single individual (den Enkelte)*, *anxiety or dread (Angest / Angst)*, *the leap (Springet)*, *being-there (Dasein)*, *being-in-the-world (In-der-Welt-sein)*, *ready-to-hand (Zuhandenheit)*, *present-at-hand (Vorhandenheit)*, *thrownness (Geworfenheit)*, *care (Sorge)*, *the "they" (das Man)*, *falling (Verfallen)*, *authenticity (Eigentlichkeit)*, *being-toward-death (Sein-zum-Tode)*, *temporality (Zeitlichkeit)*, *being-in-itself (en-soi)*, *being-for-itself (pour-soi)*, *nihilation (neantisation)*, *bad faith (mauvaise foi)*, *facticity (facticité)*, *the Look (le regard)*. *Being and Time* is cited by **Section number**, stable across the Macquarrie and Robinson (1962) and Stambaugh (1996, rev. Schmidt 2010) translations; Kierkegaard's pseudonymous books are cited **by pseudonym**, following the "First and Last Declaration" appended to the *Postscript* (1846); and Sartre's slogans are dated to the lecture of **October 1945**, published **1946**, not to *Being and Nothingness* (**1943**). *Being and Time* (1927) is **unfinished**: Division III was never published.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	14
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the provenance, dating, translation and ownership errors that cost marks every year in this clause.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. Decode the directive first: three of the fourteen owned parts hand you a **statement**, and for those the first move is always to locate the sentence inside its own author's system.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band.
5. Check every answer against the traps: the ownership of the slogan, the pseudonym attribution, the non-moral reading of authenticity, and the difference in kind between fear and anxiety.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated, and no cycle such as ABCD can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Existence and Essence*; *Choice, Responsibility and Authentic Existence*; *Being-in-the-world and Temporality* - together with the family-label warning and the ownership of the slogan, "truth is subjectivity" and its dialectical complement, the structural form of the anti-Hegelian argument, the three spheres with their characteristic collapses, the leap against mediation, the teleological suspension staged by Johannes de Silentio, anxiety as objectless and despair as a misrelation, indirect communication and the printed attribution rule, the paper-knife argument and the exact place of atheism in it, Heidegger's repudiation and *Being and Time* Section 9, the in-itself/for-itself distinction and both halves of the non-self-identity formula, nihilation and the impossible synthesis, non-choice as choice, the three moods of the 1945 lecture, the facticity/transcendence structure of bad faith, the self-deception paradox and its pre-reflective solution, motive-constitution against determinism, the Look and shame as recognition, and the two failing strategies that yield conflict. The eight remedial drills attack the confusions that cost marks every year: the provenance of the slogans, the unfinished state of *Being and Time*, the correct rendering of *das Nichts nichtet*, the Lowrie/Hong split over *Angest*, the non-moral status of authenticity, the corrected reading of "hell is other people", the derived rather than defective status of clock-time, and the ownership fence around Topics 02, 05, 07 and 09, Nietzsche and Paper II.

MCQ 1. What kind of thing "existentialism" is

Which statement most accurately describes the standing of the term "existentialism" in relation to the three thinkers printed in the syllabus?

- A. It is a retrospective family label that only Sartre accepted and defined for himself.
- B. It is a school founded by Kierkegaard, systematised by Heidegger and popularised in France by Sartre after the Second World War.
- C. It is a method of philosophical analysis that all three thinkers applied to different subject-matters while sharing its procedural rules.
- D. It is a doctrine whose founding thesis is that human beings have no nature, a thesis each of the three defended in his own vocabulary.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Kierkegaard died in 1855 and never met the word; Heidegger explicitly denied the label in the "Letter on Humanism"; only Sartre accepted it and, in the 1945 lecture published in 1946, defined it.
- **B:** Incorrect: it invents a lineage. Kierkegaard founded nothing called existentialism, and Heidegger's fundamental ontology is not a systematisation of Kierkegaard's religious writings.
- **C:** Incorrect: there is no shared procedure - Kierkegaard writes indirectly through pseudonyms, Heidegger conducts an existential analytic, Sartre a phenomenological ontology.
- **D:** Incorrect: the "no nature" thesis in that form is Sartre's, and Heidegger repudiated precisely the humanistic reading it presupposes.

Examiner trap 1: Writing "the existentialists held that..." assumes a shared doctrine, and the assumption is refuted by two of the three printed thinkers, one of whom denied the label in print and one of whom died before it existed.

MCQ 2. Which printed limb belongs almost entirely to one thinker

The syllabus prints three limbs: *Existence and Essence*; *Choice, Responsibility and Authentic Existence*; *Being-in-the-world and Temporality*. Which claim about their distribution is correct?

- A. The first limb is Heidegger's, since only he analyses the essence of Dasein as lying in its existence.
- B. The second limb is Kierkegaard's, since only he treats choice as a qualitative leap rather than as deliberation.
- C. The third limb is almost entirely Heidegger's, with Sartre entering only as a contrast.
- D. All three limbs are shared equally, which is why the syllabus names three thinkers rather than one.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the first limb turns on Sartre's slogan and on Heidegger's repudiation of it, so it cannot be assigned to Heidegger alone.
- **B:** Incorrect: choice, responsibility and authenticity are handled by all three in incompatible registers - faith, freedom and finitude.
- **C:** Correct: being-in-the-world and temporality are Heideggerian technical structures; Sartre's ecstatic temporality is read off freedom, not off Being, and Kierkegaard's "moment" is a different concept entirely.
- **D:** Incorrect: the asymmetry is exactly why 2019 Q3(a) and 2022 Q2(a) are Heidegger questions while 2024 Q4(a) is a comparison question.

Examiner trap 2: Distributing the three limbs evenly across the three thinkers produces an answer that spends a third of a Heidegger question on Kierkegaard, which is the commonest way of failing 2022 Q2(a).

MCQ 3. What "truth is subjectivity" asserts

The thesis that truth is subjectivity is argued in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846). What does it assert?

- A. That no proposition is true independently of someone's believing it, so that objective truth is an illusion produced by grammar.
- B. That for ethical and religious truth the mode of appropriation is decisive, without denying objective truth in logic or history.
- C. That the passion with which a belief is held is evidence for its truth, so that sincerity functions as a criterion of correctness.
- D. That truth is whatever the existing individual finds it useful to affirm in the situation in which he is placed.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Climacus denies the *sufficiency* of objective truth for existential matters, not its existence; logic and history retain their objective standing.
- **B:** Correct: the thesis concerns the *how* of appropriation - infinite passionate inwardness, commitment, risk - for truths that must be lived rather than merely known.
- **C:** Incorrect: passion is the mode of relation, not evidence; treating it as a criterion converts the thesis into the relativism it is designed to avoid.
- **D:** Incorrect: usefulness is a pragmatist criterion nowhere present in the *Postscript*, and it makes existential truth a matter of convenience.

Examiner trap 3: Reading the thesis as relativism makes its companion sentence "subjectivity is untruth" unintelligible, which is the internal evidence that the relativist reading cannot be right.

MCQ 4. The function of "subjectivity is untruth"

Why does Climacus also assert that subjectivity is untruth?

- A. Because the existing subject stands in sin and finitude and therefore needs the leap.
- B. Because subjective certainty is unreliable and must always be corrected by objective inquiry conducted in a community of enquirers.
- C. Because the pseudonymous form requires each thesis to be balanced by its opposite in order to preserve the reader's freedom to choose.
- D. Because passion distorts judgement, so that the more inwardly a belief is held the less likely it is to correspond to how things are.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the existing subject is not identical with the eternal, and the recognition of that non-identity is what makes the leap necessary rather than optional.
- **B:** Incorrect: the sentence is not an epistemological caution about unreliable feelings; it is a claim about the subject's standing before God.
- **C:** Incorrect: this makes the sentence a formal device of the method rather than a substantive theological claim, which reverses the order of explanation.
- **D:** Incorrect: it converts a doctrine about sin and finitude into a psychological generalisation about bias.

Examiner trap 4: Quoting "truth is subjectivity" without its complement leaves the relativism charge unanswered; quoting both, and explaining why a relativist could not use the second, answers it in one sentence.

MCQ 5. The structure of Kierkegaard's objection to Hegel

Which formulation best captures the *structural* form of Kierkegaard's objection to Hegel's system?

- A. The system is internally inconsistent, since its categories cannot be derived from one another without circularity at the decisive transitions.
- B. The system is empirically false, since history does not in fact display the rational development the dialectic requires it to display.
- C. No system can contain the one who builds it: a logical system is possible, an existential system is not.
- D. The system is morally objectionable, since it subordinates the suffering of individuals to the achievements of the world-spirit.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: internal inconsistency is a Hegelian-scholarship dispute; Kierkegaard's point holds even if the derivations succeed.
- **B:** Incorrect: an empirical objection would be answerable by better history, whereas Kierkegaard's objection concerns what any completed system must omit.
- **C:** Correct: the systematiser must still exist, choose and die, so the existing individual is the one item the system cannot absorb without cancelling it.
- **D:** Incorrect: the moral complaint is a consequence some critics draw, not the argument Kierkegaard actually mounts.

Examiner trap 5: Reducing the critique to "Kierkegaard disliked abstraction" removes the argument and leaves a temperament, which is why the 2023 part asks specifically how he argues *in favour of the individual as the essence of spirit*.

MCQ 6. The three spheres and their limits

Which pairing of sphere and characteristic collapse is correct throughout?

- A. Aesthetic - guilt; ethical - paradox; religious - boredom.
- B. Aesthetic - paradox; ethical - boredom; religious - guilt.
- C. Aesthetic - guilt; ethical - boredom; religious - paradox.
- D. Aesthetic - boredom; ethical - guilt; religious - paradox.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the sequence entirely; boredom belongs to a life organised around the interesting, not to faith.
- **B:** Incorrect: paradox is the structure of faith, which is the religious sphere, and it cannot characterise the aesthetic.
- **C:** Incorrect: guilt arises from the impossibility of perfectly fulfilling a universal ethical demand, so it belongs to the ethical sphere.
- **D:** Correct: nothing binds in the aesthetic, so the self fragments; the ethical demand cannot be perfectly met, so guilt arises; faith is not rational or universal, so it lives as paradox.

Examiner trap 6: Listing the spheres without their internal collapses makes them look like preferences; naming the collapse of each is what shows why a leap to the next becomes intelligible.

MCQ 7. The leap, and the phrase "leap of faith"

Which statement about the transition between spheres and the phrase "leap of faith" is correct?

- A. The transition is a Hegelian mediation performed at a higher level, and "leap of faith" is Kierkegaard's own term for it in *Fear and Trembling*.
- B. The transition is a gradual psychological maturation, and "leap of faith" translates the Danish *Troens Spring* exactly as Kierkegaard wrote it.
- C. The transition is a qualitative leap, and "leap of faith" is the English tradition's fused phrase rather than a Kierkegaardian term.
- D. The transition is a leap only from the ethical to the religious, and elsewhere the movement between spheres proceeds by ordinary deliberation.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the leap is defined against mediation, and the fused English phrase is not Kierkegaard's.
- **B:** Incorrect: maturation would make the movement continuous, which is precisely what "qualitative" denies.
- **C:** Correct: Kierkegaard writes of *the leap* and of faith; the compound phrase belongs to the English reception, and saying so in one clause discharges the provenance caution.
- **D:** Incorrect: the spheres are qualitatively distinct throughout, and relapse from any of them is always possible.

Examiner trap 7: Presenting the spheres as a developmental ladder implies that one grows out of the aesthetic, whereas Kierkegaard's point is that one leaps and can always fall back.

MCQ 8. Who analyses Abraham, and what the analysis does

Fear and Trembling (1843) treats Abraham under the heading of the teleological suspension of the ethical. Which statement is correct?

- A. It is written by Johannes de Silentio, who admires faith without possessing it, and it stages the paradox rather than licensing private revelation.
- B. It is written by Kierkegaard under his own name, and it establishes that a direct divine command may override the moral law whenever the individual is sincere.
- C. It is written by Johannes Climacus, whose humorist standpoint allows him to describe the knight of faith from within the religious sphere itself.
- D. It is written by Anti-Climacus, and it shows that the ethical is permanently cancelled once the individual enters the religious sphere of existence.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the pseudonym's name records his position - he can describe Abraham but not understand him - and the text presents the paradox of faith rather than a moral permission.
- **B:** Incorrect: the book is pseudonymous, and reading it as a licence for private revelation is the standard misuse Kierkegaard scholarship warns against.
- **C:** Incorrect: Climacus writes the *Fragments* and the *Postscript* and describes himself as not a Christian; he is not the author of *Fear and Trembling*.
- **D:** Incorrect: Anti-Climacus writes *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) and *Practice in Christianity* (1850), and the ethical is suspended in relation to a higher telos, not abolished.

Examiner trap 8: Attributing pseudonymous books to Kierkegaard ignores an instruction he printed himself in the "First and Last Declaration", where he asks that the pseudonym be quoted instead.

MCQ 9. What makes anxiety philosophically disclosive

On the analysis given in *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), what distinguishes anxiety from fear?

- A. Anxiety is more intense than fear, and its greater intensity overwhelms the capacity to identify what is threatening.
- B. Anxiety concerns future harms while fear concerns present ones, so the two differ only in the temporal location of the object that each of them takes.
- C. Anxiety has no determinate object, so what it discloses is not an entity but possibility - freedom's own "possibility of being able".
- D. Anxiety is a mood while fear is an emotion, and moods differ from emotions in lacking any intentional structure whatever.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: intensity would make the two differ in degree, whereas the analysis requires a difference in kind.
- **B:** Incorrect: fear can be directed at future harms and remain fear; the distinguishing feature is objectlessness, not tense.
- **C:** Correct: because there is no entity for anxiety to be about, what it discloses must be a structure, and Vigilius Haufniensis names that structure the dizziness of freedom.
- **D:** Incorrect: it introduces a mood/emotion taxonomy the text does not use, and denying all intentional structure would make anxiety mere confusion.

Examiner trap 9: Describing anxiety as "fear without a clear cause" preserves the object and merely makes it obscure, which loses the argument that an objectless state must be disclosing something other than an object.

MCQ 10. Despair, as *The Sickness unto Death* defines it

What is despair, on the analysis given by Anti-Climacus in 1849?

- A. A prolonged emotional condition of hopelessness that follows repeated failure to realise the projects one has chosen.
- B. A misrelation in the relation the self is - the self failing to be itself before the power that established it.
- C. The recognition that the ethical demand cannot be fulfilled, which drives the individual out of the ethical sphere.
- D. The mood in which the possibility of one's own death first becomes an issue for the existing individual as such.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: despair on this account may be entirely unfelt, so it cannot be identified with an emotional condition.
- **B:** Correct: the self is defined as a relation that relates itself to itself and thereby to the power that established it, and despair is a fault within that relation.
- **C:** Incorrect: that describes the collapse of the ethical sphere into guilt, which is a different analysis in a different pseudonymous work.
- **D:** Incorrect: this conflates despair with anxiety, and imports a Heideggerian concern that Kierkegaard's text does not carry.

Examiner trap 10: Treating despair as sadness makes the claim that despair is universal look like an empirical exaggeration, when it is a structural claim about the self's relation to its ground.

MCQ 11. Why the doctrine forces the method

Consider the following claims about indirect communication.

1. It is required because ethical and religious truth is a mode of existing rather than a result.
2. It is required because Kierkegaard wished to protect himself from censorship and from the Danish church.
3. Direct communication of such truth would falsify it, since the recipient could then hold it without becoming it.
4. The model is Socratic midwifery, in which the author becomes a vanishing occasion rather than an authority.

Which of the above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only.
- B. 2 and 3 only.
- C. 1, 2 and 4 only.
- D. 1, 3 and 4 only.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it includes the biographical motive, which is not the argument, and omits the two steps that make the argument work.
- **B:** Incorrect: it retains the biographical motive and drops the premise about what kind of truth is at stake.
- **C:** Incorrect: 4 is correct but 2 is not, and dropping 3 removes the step in which the falsification actually occurs.
- **D:** Correct: the three steps form the argument - the kind of truth, the falsification that direct transmission would cause, and the Socratic form that avoids it.

Examiner trap 11: Explaining pseudonymity by the author's temperament or circumstances converts an argument into a biography, and loses the point that the form is deduced from the doctrine.

MCQ 12. The "First and Last Declaration"

What does Kierkegaard do in the "First and Last Declaration" appended to the *Postscript* (1846)?

- A. He renounces the pseudonymous authorship entirely and asks readers to disregard the books published under invented names.
- B. He acknowledges the pseudonymous books while calling himself their "author's author" and asks that citations name the pseudonym.
- C. He explains that the pseudonyms were adopted to avoid prosecution, and announces that he will henceforth publish only under his own name.
- D. He identifies each pseudonym with a stage of his own biography, so that the works may be read as a spiritual autobiography.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: he does not renounce them; he acknowledges authorship while refusing to be quoted as their speaker.
- **B:** Correct: he describes himself as only the "author's author", a prompter (*souffleur*) who produced characters, and asks that the pseudonym's name be quoted instead of his own.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such legal motive is stated, and the pseudonymous works continue after 1846 with Anti-Climacus in 1849 and 1850.
- **D:** Incorrect: the pseudonyms are existence-possibilities rather than autobiographical stages, and Anti-Climacus is placed deliberately above the author himself.

Examiner trap 12: Citing "Kierkegaard in *Fear and Trembling*" is not merely loose but contrary to a printed instruction, so the correct attribution is a mark available at no cost.

MCQ 13. The exact role of atheism in the paper-knife argument

In Sartre's argument for "existence precedes essence", what role does atheism play?

- A. It is a premise: because there is no divine artisan, there is no antecedent design for the human being.
- B. It is a conclusion: the absence of any fixed human nature shows that no creator could have conceived one in advance.
- C. It is an illustration: the artisan is introduced only to make the structure of essence and existence vivid to a lay audience.
- D. It is a corollary: once freedom is recognised as absolute, the existence of a determining God is seen to be incompatible with it.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the argument runs from the absence of a designer to the absence of a blueprint, which is why the slogan in its Sartrean form is not definitional of existentialism as such.
- **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the inference; Sartre does not derive atheism from the absence of a nature.
- **C:** Incorrect: the paper-knife is the illustration; the denial of God is a substantive premise doing argumentative work.
- **D:** Incorrect: this makes atheism follow from the doctrine of freedom, whereas the lecture argues in the opposite direction.

Examiner trap 13: Missing the premissory role of atheism makes it impossible to explain why Kierkegaard, a Christian, can be an existentialist while rejecting the slogan.

MCQ 14. Heidegger on essence and existence

Which statement correctly reports Heidegger's relation to the formula "existence precedes essence"?

- A. He accepts it as a compressed statement of *Being and Time* Section 9, while regretting its use in a popular lecture rather than a technical work.
- B. He accepts its negative half - that there is no fixed human nature - while rejecting the positive claim that man creates himself.
- C. He is silent about it, since the "Letter on Humanism" concerns the history of Being and does not discuss Sartre's formulations.
- D. He repudiates it as a humanistic inversion: Section 9 makes an ontological claim, and Sartre stays inside the metaphysics of subjectivity.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: he does not accept it at all; Section 9 is expressly distinguished from the Sartrean reading.
- **B:** Incorrect: the objection is not to one half of the formula but to the framework that generates both halves.
- **C:** Incorrect: the "Letter on Humanism", written 1946 and published 1947, addresses Sartre's slogan directly.
- **D:** Correct: reversing the priority of essence and existence leaves man at the centre, which for Heidegger is the metaphysics the Being-question is meant to displace.

Examiner trap 14: Quoting Section 9 as evidence that Heidegger agrees with Sartre uses the very sentence Heidegger wrote the "Letter on Humanism" to reclaim.

MCQ 15. What kind of distinction the in-itself/for-itself distinction is

Sartre distinguishes being-in-itself from being-for-itself. What kind of distinction is this?

- A. A distinction between matter and mind, corresponding to the two substances of Cartesian dualism in a phenomenological idiom.
- B. An ontological distinction between being that is self-identical and being that is not what it is and is what it is not.
- C. An epistemological distinction between what can be known directly and what can be known only through reflective self-awareness.
- D. A distinction between the world as science describes it and the world as it appears within ordinary pre-scientific experience.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the in-itself is not matter and the for-itself is not mind; a mental state considered as a completed fact would be in-itself.
- **B:** Correct: the contrast is between full self-coincidence and constitutive non-coincidence, which is why nihilation rather than substance is the operative concept.
- **C:** Incorrect: it is not a distinction between modes of knowing but between modes of being.
- **D:** Incorrect: that is a contrast between attitudes to one world, not a division of being into two regions.

Examiner trap 15: Translating the pair as "matter and mind" makes the impossible synthesis of a *pour-soi-en-soi* look like a mind-body union rather than the contradictory ideal of a self-identical consciousness.

MCQ 16. Both halves of the formula

"Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." Which reading gives both halves correctly?

- A. "Is what it is not" - it is defined by a future it does not yet possess; "is not what it is" - it cannot coincide with its past or facticity.
- B. "Is what it is not" - it cannot coincide with its past; "is not what it is" - it is defined by a future it does not yet possess.
- C. "Is what it is not" - it misdescribes itself in bad faith; "is not what it is" - it can always revise the description it has given.
- D. "Is what it is not" - it depends on the Other for the being it has; "is not what it is" - it refuses the fixed identity that the Other's look confers upon it.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the first half is the projective, futural dimension and the second the refusal of coincidence with facticity, illustrated by the waiter who is and is not a waiter.
- **B:** Incorrect: it swaps the halves, which destroys the connection between the first half and the project.
- **C:** Incorrect: bad faith is an *application* of the formula, not its meaning; the formula states an ontological structure.
- **D:** Incorrect: being-for-others is a further dimension analysed in Part III, not the content of this formula.

Examiner trap 16: Unpacking only one half turns a fifteen-mark question into a definition, since the whole point is that the two halves name the future and the past dimensions of one non-coincidence.

MCQ 17. Nihilation and the impossible synthesis

Which statement about nihilation and the for-itself's desire is correct?

- A. Nihilation destroys the in-itself, and the for-itself's desire is to complete that destruction so that only consciousness remains.
- B. Nihilation introduces nothingness into being, and the for-itself desires to become self-identical while remaining conscious - an impossible ideal.
- C. Nihilation is the act by which the for-itself denies the existence of the world outside consciousness, and its desire is to sustain that denial indefinitely.
- D. Nihilation is the negation of one's past, and the for-itself desires to be free of every past so that no facticity constrains it.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: nihilation does not annihilate anything; it introduces distance, question and possibility into what is.
- **B:** Correct: consciousness stands back from what is and negates it, and the resulting ideal - a *pour-soi-en-soi*, that is, God - is contradictory, which is why man is called a useless passion.
- **C:** Incorrect: Sartre affirms the in-itself's brute existence; nothing in the doctrine denies that the world is.
- **D:** Incorrect: this narrows nihilation to one of its exercises and replaces the impossible synthesis with an ordinary wish.

Examiner trap 17: Omitting the impossible synthesis leaves the account without its conclusion, and the phrase "useless passion" then looks like rhetoric rather than the result of an argument.

MCQ 18. Non-choice

"I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing." What does this assert?

- A. That deliberation must terminate in a decision, since an indefinitely postponed deliberation is not a genuine deliberation at all.
- B. That every choice, however trivial, has consequences for others and therefore carries a responsibility one cannot decline.
- C. That some situations offer no acceptable options, in which case refusing to act is the only responsible course available.
- D. That deferral and conformity are themselves stances, so that the attempt to escape choosing is already a choice.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim is not about the logic of deliberation but about the impossibility of a stance-free relation to a situation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the universalisability point, which is a further thesis and not what this sentence states.
- **C:** Incorrect: it converts a structural claim into practical advice for hard cases.
- **D:** Correct: because the for-itself must take up some relation to its situation, non-choice is a way of choosing, and it is typically a way of choosing in bad faith.

Examiner trap 18: Reading the sentence as a maxim about procrastination loses its ontological force, and the 2021 part explicitly asks for Sartre's *conception of choice and responsibility* in its light.

MCQ 19. The three moods of the 1945 lecture

In *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, what do anguish, abandonment and despair respectively name?

- A. Fear of death; loss of religious belief; recognition that most projects fail.
- B. Vertigo before freedom; the loss of community; resignation in the face of history.
- C. Vertigo before one's own freedom; the absence of any *a priori* value; acting without reliance on outcomes beyond one's action.
- D. Guilt before others; the absence of divine forgiveness; the impossibility of ever completing any project that one has begun in the course of a finite life.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: none of the three is about death, belief-loss or the frequency of failure; each names a structural feature of choosing without a given framework.
- **B:** Incorrect: the first term is right but abandonment concerns the absence of *a priori* values, not the loss of community.
- **C:** Correct: anguish is vertigo before one's own undetermined future, abandonment is the absence of any value written in an intelligible heaven, and despair is the discipline of confining oneself to what lies within one's action.
- **D:** Incorrect: guilt and forgiveness belong to a theological register that Sartre's lecture does not use.

Examiner trap 19: Translating Sartre's *desespoir* by Kierkegaard's despair merges a lecture-term about reliance on outcomes with a theological account of the self's misrelation to its ground.

MCQ 20. The structure of bad faith

Which formulation states the structure of bad faith correctly?

- A. It is the deliberate assertion of what one knows to be false, directed at oneself rather than at another person.
- B. It is the repression of an unwelcome truth, which then continues to operate on conduct from outside conscious awareness.
- C. It is the failure to act on values one sincerely holds, and it is therefore a species of weakness of will rather than of deception.
- D. It is the collapse of the tension between facticity and transcendence, by living as though only one dimension were real.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is ordinary lying redirected inwards, and it generates the paradox Sartre's analysis is designed to solve rather than solving it.
- **B:** Incorrect: repression requires the Freudian unconscious, which Sartre explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Incorrect: weakness of will concerns motivation, whereas bad faith concerns the ontological description one gives of oneself.
- **D:** Correct: both dimensions are always present, and bad faith deletes one of them - the waiter's claim to be his role, or the flight from a situation's real meaning.

Examiner trap 20: Defining bad faith as self-deception in general omits the pair of terms the doctrine turns on, and the 2018 part cannot then be answered, since it asks how bad faith connects with inauthenticity and alienation.

MCQ 21. The self-deception paradox

How does Sartre answer the objection that self-deception is impossible because the deceiver must know what the deceived does not?

- A. By denying that consciousness is self-identical, so that truth and its denial can be held in a single pre-reflective, non-thetic stance.
- B. By dividing the person into a censoring agency and a censored one, which is precisely what the analysis of the unconscious was designed to supply.
- C. By arguing that the deception is temporally staggered, so that one knows at one moment and has genuinely forgotten at the next.
- D. By treating bad faith as a limiting ideal that is never fully achieved, so that the paradox describes something no one actually does.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: because the for-itself is not what it is, it can be aware without avowing, and no second person inside the person is required.
- **B:** Incorrect: Sartre rejects the Freudian unconscious precisely because it reintroduces a small deceiver within the self.
- **C:** Incorrect: staggering the knowledge would make bad faith ordinary forgetting, which cannot explain its motivated character.
- **D:** Incorrect: Sartre treats bad faith as widespread and describable, not as an unrealisable limit.

Examiner trap 21: Solving the paradox by importing the unconscious contradicts the position being expounded, and it also removes the reason Sartre needs the non-self-identity thesis in the first place.

MCQ 22. Freedom and determinism

On Sartre's account, why does a motive not determine action?

- A. Because motives are mental events without causal power, and only physical events can stand in causal relations to bodily movements.
- B. Because the for-itself is able to suspend any of its motives by an act of will, and any motive that is suspended has by that very fact been overridden.
- C. Because motives conflict with one another, and where several motives are present none of them can be singled out as the determining one.
- D. Because a motive acquires action-guiding force only through the meaning conferred on it, and that conferral is itself an act of the for-itself.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sartre is not defending epiphenomenalism or any thesis about the causal powers of the mental.
- **B:** Incorrect: this makes freedom a faculty of veto exercised over pre-existing forces, which is the voluntarism the analysis avoids.
- **C:** Incorrect: conflict among motives is a psychological commonplace and would leave determinism untouched.
- **D:** Correct: no motive operates as an external cause, because what makes it a motive is the significance it has within a project the for-itself is pursuing.

Examiner trap 22: Presenting Sartre as denying that circumstances constrain anything produces the caricature critics attack, whereas the doctrine concedes facticity and denies only that the for-itself becomes a thing among causes.

MCQ 23. The Look

What does Sartre's analysis of the Look establish?

- A. That other minds exist, since the behaviour of others cannot be explained without attributing consciousness to them.
- B. That the body is primarily an object for others, and only secondarily the medium of one's own practical engagement.
- C. That shame is by its structure shame before someone, so that the Other is lived rather than inferred as the condition of my having an outside.
- D. That social roles are imposed on us from without, so that the self is simply a product of the expectations other people direct towards it over time.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the analysis is not an argument from behaviour to consciousness; it describes a structure already present in shame.
- **B:** Incorrect: the body-for-others is a consequence drawn later, not the result the keyhole scene establishes.
- **C:** Correct: in being ashamed I recognise myself as the Other sees me, which is why Sartre calls the Other the indispensable mediator between myself and me.
- **D:** Incorrect: this sociological reading loses the ontological point that the outside conferred cannot be known from within.

Examiner trap 23: Retelling the keyhole scene without the first stage removes the crucial premise that pre-reflective consciousness is egoless, so the ego that appears under the Look no longer looks conferred.

MCQ 24. Why conflict follows

Sartre concludes that conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others. Which pair of reasons supports that conclusion?

- A. Others compete for scarce goods, and scarcity is the permanent background against which all human relations are formed.
- B. Others judge us by standards we did not set, and no standard set by another can be authoritative for a free being.
- C. Others are opaque to us, and the impossibility of knowing another's inner life makes stable cooperation permanently insecure.
- D. Assimilating the Other's freedom destroys the freedom it seeks, and objectifying him destroys the recognition it wants.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: scarcity belongs to the *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960), not to the argument of 1943.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a claim about the authority of norms rather than about the structure of the encounter.
- **C:** Incorrect: opacity is an epistemic difficulty; Sartre's conflict is ontological and arises even where each party understands the other perfectly.
- **D:** Correct: love and masochism fail because being loved is being made an object, and indifference, sadism and hate fail because an object cannot confer recognition.

Examiner trap 24: Listing the two strategies without saying why each fails leaves the conclusion unsupported, and the failure-reasons are precisely what a fifteen- or twenty-mark answer is being paid for.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - where the slogans come from

Which statement about the provenance of Sartre's best-known phrases is correct?

- A. "Condemned to be free" and "existence precedes essence" both appear in *Being and Nothingness* (1943), and the 1945 lecture merely repeats them.
- B. Both phrases come from the lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, delivered in October 1945 and published in 1946.
- C. "Existence precedes essence" is from *Being and Nothingness* (1943) and "condemned to be free" from the *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960).
- D. Both phrases were coined by Sartre's critics and adopted by him only after the label "existentialism" had become current in France.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the 1943 treatise is a technical ontology and does not contain the popular formulations.
- **B:** Correct: the slogans belong to the popular lecture, which Sartre later regretted publishing - a point worth one clause in any answer.
- **C:** Incorrect: it splits the pair across the wrong works and dates one of them seventeen years too late.
- **D:** Incorrect: the phrases are Sartre's own, and the lecture is where he sets them out.

Examiner trap 25: Sourcing the slogans to *Being and Nothingness* misses the difference between a technical ontology and a popular defence, and the distinction is exactly the kind of precision the paper rewards.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - the state of Being and Time

Which statement about *Being and Time* (1927) is correct?

- A. It was published complete in 1927, and the later "turn" abandoned its conclusions in favour of a new starting point in language.
- B. It was published in two volumes, the second of which appeared in 1929 under the title "What is Metaphysics?".
- C. It was published unfinished: only Divisions One and Two of Part One appeared, and Division III was never published.
- D. It was published unfinished, and Heidegger completed it in the Stambaugh edition of 1996 with the addition of the missing division.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the book is incomplete on its own terms, and the turn is a change of approach rather than the abandonment of a finished result.
- **B:** Incorrect: "What is Metaphysics?" is the 1929 Freiburg inaugural lecture, not a second volume.
- **C:** Correct: Division III ("Time and Being") and the whole of Part Two were never published, which is why one must never write that Heidegger completes his analysis of Being in the book.
- **D:** Incorrect: Stambaugh's 1996 volume is a translation, and it adds no missing text.

Examiner trap 26: Writing that *Being and Time* completes the analysis of Being asserts something the book itself denies, and it removes the internal objection that any critical account of Heidegger should register.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - rendering das Nichts nichtet

In "What is Metaphysics?" (1929) Heidegger writes *Das Nichts nichtet*. Which rendering is acceptable?

- A. "Nothing noths", or equivalently "the nothing nothings".
- B. "Nothing noughts", which preserves the play on the arithmetical zero in the German original.
- C. "Nothingness annihilates", which conveys the destructive force the German verb is intended to express.
- D. "There is nothing", which avoids the neologism while retaining the sense of the sentence for an English reader.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the standard renderings, and the coined verb is deliberate - the Nothing is presented as doing something rather than as a mere absence.
- **B:** Incorrect: "noughts" is simply wrong, and the German makes no arithmetical play.
- **C:** Incorrect: "annihilates" imports a destructive sense the analysis does not carry; the point is disclosure, not destruction.
- **D:** Incorrect: rendering it as an existential denial removes the verb and with it the whole provocation Carnap attacked.

Examiner trap 27: Reproducing "nothing noughts" signals that the sentence has been copied from an unreliable summary, and it also weakens the cross-reference to the logical-positivist attack, which turns on the exact wording.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - translating Angest

Why should an answer name a translation, or use the Danish word once, when discussing Kierkegaard's *Angest*?

- A. Because the Danish term has no English equivalent, so any translation misrepresents the concept it names.
- B. Because Lowrie renders it "dread" and Hong renders it "anxiety", and the book's English title differs accordingly.
- C. Because Kierkegaard used the term inconsistently across his works, so each occurrence has to be dated before it can be translated.
- D. Because the German *Angst* and the Danish *Angest* are false friends, and the two words name unrelated states.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the term is translatable; the difficulty is that two standard traditions translate it differently.
- **B:** Correct: *The Concept of Dread* (Lowrie) and *The Concept of Anxiety* (Hong) are the same book, and naming the translation prevents an apparent contradiction.
- **C:** Incorrect: the difficulty is one of reception rather than of authorial inconsistency.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two are cognate and the analyses are related, though not identical - which is a point about doctrine, not about translation.

Examiner trap 28: Referring to "*The Concept of Dread*" and "*The Concept of Anxiety*" as two works doubles Kierkegaard's bibliography and reveals that the sources were not checked against one another.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - the status of authenticity

Which statement about Heidegger's *Eigentlichkeit* is correct?

- A. It is a moral virtue whose opposite, inauthenticity, is a culpable failure to live according to one's own standards.
- B. It is a psychological achievement in which anxiety is mastered and the fear of death is finally overcome.
- C. It is an existential modification, not a moral category; Dasein is inauthentic proximally and for the most part, and this is structural.
- D. It is a political stance, since resoluteness is said to require commitment to a historical community and to the destiny it has inherited.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: inauthenticity carries no blame, because falling is an ontological structure rather than a failure of will.
- **B:** Incorrect: anticipatory resoluteness is not the mastery of a feeling; being-toward-death concerns a possibility, not an emotion.
- **C:** Correct: authenticity changes the ownership of an existence rather than its moral quality, and the call of conscience issues no content whatever.
- **D:** Incorrect: this reads the later political catastrophe back into the analysis, which is the objection critics press rather than the doctrine itself.

Examiner trap 29: Glossing authenticity as "being true to yourself" imports a popular ideal, and it makes the strongest objection - that the doctrine is formally empty - impossible to state.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - "hell is other people"

How should the line from *Huis clos* (1944) be handled in an answer?

- A. Quote it, then give Sartre's own correction: it describes twisted relations, and the characters are dead and therefore fixed.
- B. Quote it as Sartre's considered view that human relations are inherently poisonous and cannot be improved by any effort.
- C. Avoid it entirely, since a line from a play carries no philosophical weight and cannot be cited in a philosophy answer.
- D. Quote it as evidence that Sartre abandoned the ontology of *Being and Nothingness* in favour of a literary treatment of the same themes.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Sartre explained in a 1965 recorded preface that the line does not mean relations with others are always poisonous, and that the three characters can no longer change their acts.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the popular misreading the author himself corrected.
- **C:** Incorrect: the line follows from the analysis of being-for-others and is legitimately citable when its context is supplied.
- **D:** Incorrect: the play and the treatise are contemporaneous and mutually supporting, not successive positions.

Examiner trap 30: Quoting the line without the correction converts an ontological thesis about objectification into a slogan about misanthropy, and it forfeits an easy demonstration of familiarity with the source.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - ordinary time

Which statement about Heidegger's treatment of ordinary or "vulgar" time is correct?

- A. Clock-time is an illusion produced by falling, and authentic Dasein dispenses with measurement altogether.
- B. Clock-time is a derived interpretation reached through world-time and public dating; "vulgar" names a levelling, not a moral defect.
- C. Clock-time and primordial temporality are two wholly independent structures, and neither of them is derivable from the other in either direction.
- D. Clock-time is primordial, and Dasein's ecstatic temporality is a subjective distortion of the objective now-series.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: clock measurement is practically indispensable, and nothing in the analysis condemns it.
- **B:** Correct: the derivation runs from ecstatic temporality through world-time to public dating and measurement, and the levelling concerns a conceptual interpretation rather than conduct.
- **C:** Incorrect: independence would defeat the point of Division Two, which is to show the derivative status of the ordinary conception.
- **D:** Incorrect: it reverses the order of foundation the analysis is constructed to establish.

Examiner trap 31: Treating "vulgar time" as inauthentic in a moral sense converts a claim about the order of foundation into a complaint about punctuality, and overclaiming here is a standard way of losing the assessment marks.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - the ownership fence

Which item is correctly assigned to this syllabus clause rather than to another owner?

- A. The theory of essences and free imaginative variation, since Heidegger and Sartre both employ phenomenological method.
- B. The dialectical method and the doctrine of Absolute Spirit, since Kierkegaard's whole position is defined against them.
- C. The doctrine of eternal recurrence and the will to power, since Nietzsche is standardly grouped with the existentialists in survey histories.
- D. Heidegger's rejection of the transcendental ego, since the burden of that argument is his own account of being-in-the-world.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the theory of essences and imaginative variation belong to Topic 09, Phenomenology (Husserl); this clause owns only Heidegger's redirection of the method.
- **B:** Incorrect: Hegel's dialectic and Absolute Spirit belong to Topic 05; here Hegel is the target, stated in two clauses.
- **C:** Incorrect: Nietzsche is not a printed thinker in this clause, so nihilism, will to power and recurrence are not owner content.
- **D:** Correct: the 2018 part is routed here because its argumentative burden is Heidegger's being-in-the-world, with the *epoche* attributed to Husserl in a single accurate sentence.

Examiner trap 32: Expounding Husserl's method, Hegel's dialectic or Nietzsche's nihilism inside this clause spends marks on another owner's territory while leaving the printed thinkers under-treated.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answers for Philosophy Paper I. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the typographic quotation marks the repository ledger records and the printed spelling of names. The 2018 to 2025 Paper I texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. *Being and Time* is cited by **Section number**, which is stable across the Macquarrie and Robinson (1962) and Stambaugh (1996, revised Schmidt 2010) translations; Kierkegaard's pseudonymous works are cited **by pseudonym**, following the "First and Last Declaration" appended to the *Postscript* (1846); and Sartre's slogans are dated to the lecture of **October 1945**, published **1946**, rather than to *Being and Nothingness* (1943). Interpretive disputes - whether the leap is fideism, whether bad faith is coherent without an unconscious, whether authenticity is formally empty, and whether conflict is really the original meaning of being-for-others - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **14 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus - **joint-highest** with Rationalism and with Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein - and it owns **at least one part in every one of the eight years**. All fourteen are solved in full below, followed by **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: **Sartre** carries eight parts (2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025 and, jointly, the comparison part), **Kierkegaard** four (2020, 2022, 2023, 2024) and **Heidegger** three (2018, 2019, 2022); the twenty-mark parts cluster on Heidegger's

being-in-the-world and on Kierkegaard's subjectivity, while the ten-mark parts test single distinctions. Three of the fourteen are **statement questions** (2020 Q4(a), 2021 Q4(b), 2023 Q3(c)), and for those the first move is always to locate the sentence inside its own author's system.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: How does Sartre connect inauthenticity with bad faith? Why does Sartre show that inauthenticity and bad faith lead to alienation? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two linked "how/why" questions - a connection and then a consequence
Core issue	That bad faith, inauthenticity and alienation form an ordered chain, not a set of synonyms
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the structure, one example, the chain, one limit
Ideal thesis	Bad faith is the project, inauthenticity the resulting mode, alienation the cost
Non-negotiables	facticity and transcendence named; the waiter or the woman on the date; the pre-reflective solution flagged

Independent model answer

Thesis. Bad faith is the project, inauthenticity the mode it produces, and alienation the price the for-itself pays for it.

The structure. Human reality has two dimensions at once: **facticity** - body, past, social position, situation - and **transcendence**, the freedom to negate that given and project beyond it. **Bad faith** (*mauvaise foi*) is not ordinary lying but the collapse of this tension: I live as though only one dimension were real.

The connection. Inauthenticity follows immediately, because a consciousness that denies its own unstable freedom has adopted a settled self-description it cannot honestly hold. Sartre's woman on the date denies her **transcendence** by reducing herself to a body-object, and simultaneously denies the **facticity** of the gesture by treating it as neutral - one act, two denials.

Why alienation. The self that lives through a fixed social role, or through the objectifying **Look** of others, relates to itself as to a thing. What was mine to answer for becomes something I merely am, and the for-itself is estranged from the freedom that constitutes it.

Qualification. CAUTION: Since Sartre rejects the Freudian unconscious, the self-deception must be lodged in a **pre-reflective, non-thetic** awareness; whether that is coherent remains disputed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question contains two verbs - "connect" and "lead to" - so the answer must be a chain, not a definition.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; structure three; connection four; alienation three; qualification one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the two dimensions -> bad faith -> inauthenticity -> alienation -> limit.
- **Doctrine:** facticity/transcendence; the collapse of the tension.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Nothingness* (1943); the woman on the date; the Look.
- **Distinction:** project against mode against cost.
- **Criticism:** the coherence of self-deception without an unconscious.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: What is 'Epoche'? How does Heidegger reject this method of phenomenological reduction? Explain Heidegger's concept of 'being in the world' as opposed to the concept of a transcendental ego.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three sequenced tasks - define, reject, replace - and all three must appear
Core issue	That the objection concerns the starting point , not the accuracy, of phenomenological description
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: one accurate sentence on Husserl, then the argument, then the positive structure
Ideal thesis	The reduction begins from reflection and so presupposes what it claims to bracket; being-in-the-world is more primordial
Non-negotiables	<i>epoche</i> attributed to Husserl ; unitary structure; ready-to-hand; care; no spatial reading

Independent model answer

Thesis. Heidegger does not accuse Husserl of describing badly; he argues that the reduction begins one step too late, and being-in-the-world names the condition it presupposes.

What the epoche is. FACT: **Husserl's** suspension puts out of play the natural attitude's positing that the world exists. Nothing is denied or doubted; the belief-character is withheld so that what is given may be described purely, and the residue is **transcendental subjectivity**. ANALYSIS: It is a change of attitude, not a sceptical doubt, and it belongs to another owner in this syllabus.

The rejection. Heidegger's objection is one of **order**. A reflective suspension is available only to a spectator already set over against a world; but reflection is not the first relation Dasein has to anything. Dasein is **proximally and for the most part** absorbed in tasks, using equipment competently and understanding its situation practically. **Subject and object** are therefore **derivative abstractions** from involvement, and a method that starts by bracketing the world's existence has silently retained the framework it meant to suspend. The residue it isolates - a transcendental ego - is on this reading not the ground of world-disclosure but a late abstraction from a Dasein that was already disclosing a world. ANALYSIS: He does not abandon description; he **redirects** it toward the disclosedness of Being through care, equipment and temporality.

Being-in-the-world. FACT: The hyphens carry the doctrine: it is one **unitary** phenomenon, not subject plus relation plus world, and "in" is not spatial containment. The **world** is a **referential context of meaning**, not the totality of objects. Entities are met first as **ready-to-hand** equipment within an in-order-to chain - hammer, nail, board, house, dwelling - and the **present-at-hand** object appears later, typically through **breakdown**: unusability, absence, obstruction. ANALYSIS: Breakdown makes the network conspicuous without abolishing significance. The unity of this structure is **care** (*Sorge*, Section 41): **ahead-of-itself, already-in, alongside**. Because the compound is unitary, the Cartesian demand for a proof of the external world does not arise: the gap such a proof would bridge is an artefact of decomposing the phenomenon.

Assessment. CAUTION: The argument stands or falls on whether the subject-object pair really is derivative; and Heidegger's own project remained incomplete, since Division III was never published.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the first sentence of the question belongs to another owner. Attribute it accurately in one line and move.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; *epoche* three; rejection six; being-in-the-world eight; assessment two.

- **Structure:** define -> object -> replace -> assess.
- **Doctrine:** suspension and residue; unitary structure; equipment; care.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Time* (1927) Section 41; the in-order-to chain; breakdown modes.
- **Distinction:** rejection of a **starting point**, not of description.
- **Criticism:** the derivative status of subject and object; the unwritten Division III.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: Is Dasein authentic existence for Heidegger? How does he relate temporality with Dasein? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A yes/no ruling followed by a second, technical question; both must be answered
Core issue	That Dasein is <i>not</i> defined as authentic, and that temporality is the meaning of care
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the ruling, the modification, the three ecstases, the criticism
Ideal thesis	No - authenticity is one modification of Dasein's being, and temporality is what makes that being intelligible
Non-negotiables	<i>zunächst und zumeist</i> ; the four characters of death; the care/ecstases mapping; future-primacy

Independent model answer

Thesis. No. Dasein is not authentic existence; authenticity is one **modification** of Dasein's being, and the being so modified is **care**, whose meaning is **temporality**.

Why the ruling. FACT: Dasein is **proximally and for the most part** (*zunächst und zumeist*) inauthentic - dispersed in the "they" (*das Man*), whose marks are **idle talk**, **curiosity** and **ambiguity**, and absorbed by **falling** (*Verfallen*). ANALYSIS: This is not a moral failing but a **structural feature** of being-in-the-world, and *das Man* is not "other people" but the impersonal anyone in whose name things are done. Authenticity and inauthenticity are therefore **existential modifications** of one structure, not two kinds of person.

How authenticity arises. The **call of conscience** (Section Section 54-60) is **silent** and issues no rule; it summons Dasein back to its null responsibility for taking over its thrown projection. **Death** (Section Section 46-53) is Dasein's **ownmost, non-relational, certain** and **indefinite** possibility; the inauthentic "**one dies**" conceals its individualising force, while **anticipatory resoluteness** owns it and lets Dasein take over its existence **as a whole**. ANALYSIS: Individualisation **modifies** rather than abolishes **being-with** (Section 26).

Temporality. FACT: Division Two argues that the meaning of **care** - "ahead-of-itself, already-in, alongside" (Section 41) - is **temporality** (*Zeitlichkeit*). The three limbs map exactly: **ahead-of-itself -> future** (*Zukunft*), **already-in -> having-been** (*Gewesenheit*), **alongside -> present** (*Gegenwart*). ANALYSIS: *Gewesenheit* is not the elapsed past but the past Dasein **still is** and carries as possibility. These are **ecstases**, not segments of a line: Dasein stands out into all three simultaneously, so temporality is a finite **unity**. The **future has priority**, since past and present are temporalised out of Dasein's projection upon death - which is why authenticity is **futural** and why only a being that can relate to its own end can be grasped as a whole. Ordinary clock-time, the infinite now-series, is **derived** through world-time and public dating; ANALYSIS: "vulgar" names a **levelled interpretation**, not a moral defect. **Historicity** (*Geschichtlichkeit*) follows: possibilities are inherited and projected.

Assessment. CAUTION: The formality that keeps authenticity non-prescriptive is also the strongest objection to it, and **Division III**, where temporality was to yield the meaning of Being as such, was never published.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the ruling must arrive first; a script that describes authenticity without denying the identification has answered a question that was not asked.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: ruling one line; inauthenticity four; conscience and death five; temporality eight; assessment two.

- **Structure:** ruling -> why -> how authenticity arises -> temporality -> limit.
- **Doctrine:** *das Man*, falling, conscience, being-toward-death, the ecstases.
- **Evidence:** Section Section 27, 35-38, 41, 46-53, 54-60, 65.
- **Distinction:** modification against identity; ecstasis against segment.
- **Criticism:** formal emptiness; the unwritten Division III.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Sartre look at the problem of freedom of choice and determinism? Explain.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain" - a reconstruction with a stated position , not a debate survey
Core issue	That determinism misdescribes the for-itself, so the problem is dissolved rather than won
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the argument, the qualification, one criticism
Ideal thesis	A motive determines nothing until it is constituted as a motive
Non-negotiables	nihilation; meaning-conferral; situation; the 1960 concession

Independent model answer

Thesis. For Sartre the dispute is a **false problem**: determinism describes the for-itself in categories that belong to the in-itself.

The argument. FACT: A **motive** - a desire, an emotion, a situation - becomes a reason for action only through the **meaning** conferred on it; and meaning-conferral is itself an act of the **for-itself** (*pour-soi*), which nihilates the given and projects beyond it. Therefore no motive determines me **unless I freely constitute it as a motive**. Remove the project and the same desire motivates nothing.

Why this is not a rival causal theory. The **for-itself** is not a thing among causes. It "is what it is not and is not what it is": it cannot coincide with its past, and it is defined by a future that does not yet exist. To treat it as an *en-soi* standing in causal relations is to have changed the subject.

Situation, stated honestly. ANALYSIS: Sartre does not deny that **facticity** limits practical possibilities. Freedom is called "absolute" only in the **structural** sense that the for-itself cannot become a completed thing; "there are no excuses" concerns responsibility for **taking up** motives, not the dismissal of trauma or coercion.

Criticism. CAUTION: The account is charged with psychological and social implausibility: oppression limits not only action but the range of alternatives one can even entertain (Merleau-Ponty; Marxist, feminist and postcolonial critics). Sartre's distinction between freedom of consciousness and freedom of action answers the charge but weakens the radical thesis, and in the *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) he himself integrates **scarcity**, **seriality** and the **practico-inert** - the clearest evidence that the objection landed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the examiner is testing whether the candidate can state *why* Sartre thinks the question is malformed, not merely that he defends freedom.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis one line; argument four; ontology three; situation three; criticism three.

- **Structure:** dissolution -> argument -> ontology -> qualification -> criticism.
- **Doctrine:** nihilation; meaning-conferral; facticity.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Nothingness* (1943); *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960).
- **Distinction:** structural absoluteness against practical omnipotence.
- **Criticism:** oppression and the cognitive range of alternatives.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2020 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: What does Kierkegaard mean by saying "Subjectivity is the truth" in the context of the problem of 'the single individual'?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What does ... mean ... in the context of" - an exposition tied to a second concept
Core issue	That the thesis is about the mode of appropriation and is answerable only through the single individual
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: attribution, thesis, three denials, the complement, the method, a verdict
Ideal thesis	The thesis states how existential truth can be held, and the single individual is the only one who can hold it
Non-negotiables	Climacus; the <i>Postscript</i> (1846); "subjectivity is untruth"; "the crowd is untruth"; indirect communication

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim is not that belief makes things true but that a truth about how to exist can be possessed only in the manner of existing it - and only the **single individual** (*den Enkelte*) can do that.

Attribution. FACT: The thesis is argued by the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus** in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), a humorist who says explicitly that he is **not** a Christian, which is why he can pose the problem of becoming one.

What it asserts. For **ethical and religious** truth, the **mode of appropriation** - infinite passionate inwardness, commitment, risk - is decisive. To hold that God exists as an item in a system is not to exist before God in fear and trembling. The *how* of the relation, not the *what* of the proposition, is where truth is located for an existing subject.

Three denials. ANALYSIS: It is **not** relativism; it does **not** deny objective truth in logic or history, only its **sufficiency** for existence; and it is **not** the claim that factual truth varies with passion.

The complement that proves it. FACT: Climacus also writes "**subjectivity is untruth**": the existing subject stands in sin and finitude and therefore **needs the leap**. A relativist could make no use of that sentence.

The single individual. The thesis requires a bearer no system can absorb. To exist is to be particular, temporal, passionate and deciding - none of them a category a completed system can hold without cancelling it. Against Hegel, Kierkegaard insists that "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible", because the systematiser must still exist, choose and die; against the public, "**the crowd is untruth**", since responsibility distributed among everyone is borne by no one. The spheres of existence supply the content: appropriation intensifies from the aesthetic through the ethical to the religious, joined not by mediation but by the **leap** (*Springet*).

The method that follows. ANALYSIS: If such truth is a mode of existing, direct communication would convert it into a result and falsify it - hence **indirect communication** and the pseudonyms.

Verdict. CAUTION: Kierkegaard exposes a first-person appropriation that a system-view risks losing; he does not refute Hegel's ontology, and the fideism charge remains live.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "in the context of the single individual" is not decoration; an answer that expounds the thesis without the bearer has answered half the question.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; attribution two; assertion three; denials three; complement three; single individual five; method two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> attribution -> assertion -> denials -> complement -> bearer -> method -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** appropriation; subjectivity as untruth; the crowd; indirect communication.
- **Evidence:** *Postscript* (1846); the "First and Last Declaration".
- **Distinction:** the *how* against the *what*.

- **Criticism:** fideism; the bounded scope of the anti-Hegelian result.

Solved PYQ 6 · 2020 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: "You can always make something out of what you have been made into." Critically discuss this statement by Sartre with reference to his views on existentialism.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" a statement - locate it, unpack it, then assess
Core issue	The exact force of "always", and the concession contained in the first half
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the two halves, the ontology behind them, the objection, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The sentence concedes facticity and asserts that facticity must still be taken up
Non-negotiables	facticity/transcendence; "always" as structural; the 1960 self-revision

Independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence is not a slogan of self-help but a compressed statement of the facticity/transcendence structure, and its whole weight rests on the word "always".

"What you have been made into." FACT: Sartre **concedes the making**: class, body, upbringing, history and the objectifying gaze of others are **facticity**, the given from which any project must start. The sentence begins by granting the determinist his data.

"You can always make something out of." The for-itself is constituted by **transcendence** - the nihilating movement that surpasses what it is towards what it is not yet. Facticity is therefore never received as a completed nature; it must be **taken up** in a project, and taking it up is something the for-itself does.

What "always" means. ANALYSIS: It is a **structural** claim: there is no situation in which the for-itself becomes a thing, because it must still confer meaning on whatever it has been made into. It is **not** the promise that every outcome is available. The distinction matters, because the popular reading - that circumstances impose no limits - is the reading critics rightly attack.

Why this connects to the wider position. FACT: It follows from the atheistic argument of the 1945 lecture, published 1946: with no divine artisan there is no antecedent blueprint, so **existence precedes essence** and a person is what he makes of what he has been made into. Evading that is **bad faith** - the collapse of the facticity/transcendence tension - and non-choice is itself a choice, since "I can always choose, but if I do not choose, I am still choosing".

Criticism. CAUTION: Slavery, torture, severe illness and structural oppression limit not only action but the alternatives one can entertain; **de Beauvoir** and **Fanon** press gendered and racialised constraint. Sartre's reply distinguishes freedom of consciousness from freedom of action, which answers the objection while weakening the radical thesis; in the *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) he integrates **scarcity**, **seriality** and the **practico-inert**.

Verdict. The sentence is defensible read structurally and indefensible read practically, and Sartre's own later work is the best evidence for that division rather than an external critic's.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the concession in the first half is what most scripts miss; showing it first makes the critical section credible rather than adversarial.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; first half three; second half three; "always" three; wider position four; criticism four; verdict two.

- **Structure:** locate -> unpack both halves -> fix the modal -> connect -> criticise -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** facticity/transcendence; existence precedes essence; bad faith.
- **Evidence:** lecture 1945, published 1946; *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960).
- **Distinction:** structural against practical reading of "always".
- **Criticism:** oppression; the author's own revision.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing". Critically discuss Sartre's conception of choice and responsibility in the light of above statement.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss ... in the light of" - the statement frames a doctrine , and assessment is required
Core issue	Why non-choice is a stance, and what responsibility follows
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the structural claim, bad faith, universalisability, the objection
Ideal thesis	Because freedom is what the for-itself is, no stance-free relation to a situation is possible
Non-negotiables	freedom as constitutive; bad faith; "in choosing myself I choose man"; coercion objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence states that there is no stance-free relation to a situation, because freedom is not something the for-itself has but what it is.

The structural claim. FACT: The **for-itself** (*pour-soi*) is the nihilating, self-transcending movement that continually surpasses what it is towards what it is not yet. It cannot therefore *not* take up a relation to its circumstances. Deferral, conformity and "having no option" are ways of relating, and hence choices.

Why non-choice is typically bad faith. ANALYSIS: To present a deferral as an absence of choice is to describe oneself as a thing determined by circumstance - the collapse of **transcendence** into **facticity** that Sartre calls **bad faith** (*mauvaise foi*).

Responsibility. Since the outcome of a non-choice is produced by that non-choice, responsibility is not diminished by passivity. FACT: The 1945 lecture adds the universal dimension: "**in choosing myself, I choose man**" - each choice projects an image of what human beings ought to be, which is the source of **anguish** (*angoisse*).

Criticism. CAUTION: Is the distinction between choosing-not-to-choose and being genuinely unable to choose real? Structural oppression, coercion and severe illness appear to limit not merely action but the awareness of alternatives, and the universalisability clause sits uneasily with the denial of *a priori* values - a tension Sartre concedes, and which the unfinished *Notebooks for an Ethics* was to address. His later *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) integrates scarcity and seriality.

Verdict. Read structurally the claim is strong: no situation converts the for-itself into a thing. Read as practical advice it under-describes constraint, and that is where the criticism bites.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically discuss" means the assessment must be a third of the answer, not a closing sentence.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis one line; structural claim three; bad faith two; responsibility three; criticism four; verdict two.

- **Structure:** locate the sentence -> structural claim -> bad faith -> responsibility -> criticism -> rule.
- **Doctrine:** freedom as constitutive; non-choice as choice; universalisability.
- **Evidence:** lecture 1945, published 1946; *Notebooks for an Ethics*; the 1960 *Critique*.
- **Distinction:** structural against practical readings.
- **Criticism:** coercion and awareness of alternatives.

Solved PYQ 8 · 2022 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: Provide a critical account of Heidegger's Being-in-the-world and discuss the problem of 'authenticity' in the context of Dasein.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critical account" plus "discuss the problem" - exposition with assessment , then a second topic
Core issue	That authenticity is a modification <i>within</i> being-in-the-world, not an escape from it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the structure, worldhood, care, the "they", death, the emptiness charge
Ideal thesis	Being-in-the-world is the <i>what</i> ; authenticity is the <i>how</i>
Non-negotiables	unitary compound; ready-to-hand; care's three limbs; non-moral authenticity; formal emptiness

Independent model answer

Thesis. Being-in-the-world is the **what** of Dasein and authenticity is the **how**: a modification of that structure, never a departure from it.

The unitary structure. FACT: The hyphens are the doctrine. Being-in-the-world is one phenomenon, not subject plus relation plus world, and "in" is not spatial containment. Dasein does not first exist and then meet a world; it is constitutively engaged, absorbed, concerned. The Cartesian demand for a proof of the external world therefore does not arise: the gap it would bridge is an artefact of decomposing the phenomenon.

Worldhood. The **world** is a **referential context of meaning**. Entities are met first as **ready-to-hand** (*Zuhandenheit*) equipment within an **in-order-to** chain - hammer, nail, board, house, **dwelling** - which terminates not in a further tool but in a possibility of Dasein's own being; the **present-at-hand** (*Vorhandenheit*) object with properties emerges through **breakdown**: unusability, absence, obstruction. ANALYSIS: Breakdown makes the network conspicuous; it does not abolish significance, and the theoretical object is a **modification** of practical engagement rather than the neutral baseline.

Care and disclosedness. FACT: Dasein is always **attuned** (*Befindlichkeit*), always **understanding** by projecting upon possibilities (*Verstehen*), and always articulable (*Rede*); these constitute its **disclosedness**. Their unity is **care** (*Sorge*, Section 41): **ahead-of-itself - already-in - alongside**, collecting projection, thrownness and absorbed concern.

Authenticity. ANALYSIS: *Eigentlichkeit* is an **existential modification**, not a virtue, and Dasein is inauthentic **proximally and for the most part** - dispersed in the "they" (*das Man*) through **idle talk**, **curiosity** and **ambiguity**, and absorbed by **falling**. The **silent call of conscience** returns Dasein to its null responsibility, and **being-toward-death - ownmost, non-relational, certain, indefinite** - is owned in **anticipatory resoluteness**, which gathers existence into a whole. Individualisation **modifies** rather than abolishes **being-with** (Section 26).

Critical account. CAUTION: Three objections stand: authenticity is **formally empty**, prescribing no content, a charge sharpened by Heidegger's 1933 complicity and by Adorno's "jargon of authenticity"; **Levinas** and **Arendt** contest the primacy of death against the Other and against natality; and the project itself is unfinished, Division III never having appeared. The defence - that fundamental ontology is not ethics - is textually correct and philosophically unsatisfying.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critical account" makes assessment part of the exposition, not an appendix; the emptiness charge should be signalled before it is developed.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; structure three; worldhood five; care two; authenticity seven; criticism four.

- **Structure:** what -> how -> assess.
- **Doctrine:** unitary compound; equipment; care; *das Man*; death.
- **Evidence:** Section 26, 27, 35-38, 41, 46-53, 54-60.
- **Distinction:** modification within the structure, not escape from it.

- **Criticism:** formal emptiness; Levinas and Arendt; the unwritten division.

Solved PYQ 9 · 2022 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: How does Soren Kierkegaard define the notion of 'subjectivity'? Explain it with reference to three stages of existence as propounded by him.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Define" then "explain with reference to" - a concept plus its content , in that order
Core issue	That the spheres are the content of which subjectivity is the form
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the definition, the three spheres with their collapses, the leap, a verdict
Ideal thesis	Subjectivity is intensifying inwardness, and the spheres trace its intensification
Non-negotiables	Climacus; the <i>how</i> against the <i>what</i> ; spheres not stages; the leap; the two knights

Independent model answer

Thesis. Subjectivity names the **mode of appropriation** in which existential truth is held, and the three spheres are the successive shapes that appropriation takes.

The definition. FACT: Argued by the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus** in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846): for ethical and religious truth the **how** - infinite passionate inwardness, commitment, risk - matters more than the objective content. ANALYSIS: This is not relativism; Climacus also writes "**subjectivity is untruth**", since the existing subject stands in sin and finitude.

The aesthetic sphere. Life organised around **the interesting** - enjoyment, immediacy, irony, and the avoidance of anything binding - portrayed in *Either/Or* (1843), edited by **Victor Eremita**, who prints the aesthetic and ethical papers side by side without deciding. Its limit is **boredom** and fragmentation: nothing binds, so nothing holds the self together.

The ethical sphere. Life organised around **universal duty** - commitment, marriage, vocation, transparency - voiced by **Judge William**. Its limit is **guilt**: the demand cannot be perfectly met, and the universal cannot accommodate the individual's anguished singularity.

The religious sphere. Standing **before God** as a singular individual, with faith as "the absurd" and infinite passion. **Johannes de Silentio** stages this in *Fear and Trembling* (1843) through Abraham and the **teleological suspension of the ethical**, distinguishing the visibly renouncing **knight of infinite resignation** from the **knight of faith**, outwardly indistinguishable from an ordinary citizen because he lives fully in the finite while relating absolutely to the Absolute. Its structure is **paradox**: faith is not rational, not universal and not mediated by the crowd or the church.

The movement. ANALYSIS: Transition is a **qualitative leap** (*Springet*), not Hegelian mediation and not maturation; the spheres are **qualitative**, and relapse is always possible. The English phrase "leap of faith" is the tradition's, not Kierkegaard's, who writes of *the leap*. FACT: The connection back to the definition is exact: each sphere is a mode of appropriating existence, so the sequence from dispersion through duty to the absolute relation **is** the intensification of inwardness that subjectivity names.

Verdict. CAUTION: The spheres trace an intensification of inwardness from dispersion through duty to the absolute relation. The account is powerful against systematic closure but exposed to the **fideism** charge and to the objection that its treatment of community remains thin.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the two halves must be joined; a script that defines subjectivity and then narrates three stages without connecting them has written two answers.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; definition three; three spheres nine; movement three; verdict two.

- **Structure:** definition -> three spheres with collapses -> the leap -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** appropriation; the spheres; the teleological suspension; the two knights.

- **Evidence:** *Either/Or* and *Fear and Trembling* (1843); *Postscript* (1846).
- **Distinction:** qualitative spheres against developmental stages.
- **Criticism:** fideism; thin account of community.

Solved PYQ 10 · 2023 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: How does Kierkegaard argue against Hegel's idea of universal spirit in favour of the individual as the essence of spirit? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does ... argue" plus "critically" - a structural argument and a ruling , in ten marks
Core issue	That the objection concerns what any completed system must omit
Scope boundary	Ten marks: target, argument, one contrast pair, verdict
Ideal thesis	No system can contain the one who builds it
Non-negotiables	mediation against the leap; either/or against both/and; the bounded verdict

Independent model answer

Thesis. Kierkegaard's argument is structural: spirit is realised in the existing individual because no completed system can contain the one who builds it.

The target. FACT: Hegel's claim that reality is the self-development of **Absolute Spirit**, that oppositions are **mediated** into higher unities, and that the individual is a moment within a total rational process.

The argument. To exist is to be particular, temporal, passionate and deciding. None of these is a category the system can absorb without cancelling it, and the systematiser himself must still exist, choose and die. Hence Climacus's formula: "**a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible.**"

The contrasts that carry it. ANALYSIS: **Either/or** against **both/and**: to exist is to choose one thing rather than another, whereas mediation dissolves the exclusive choice. **The leap** (*Springet*) against **mediation**: no argument delivers me from one sphere of existence to the next. And "**the crowd is untruth**", since responsibility distributed among all is borne by none.

Verdict. CAUTION: Bounded. Kierkegaard exposes a first-person appropriation that a system-view risks losing; he does not refute Hegel's ontology, offers no rival comprehensive system, and a Hegelian may reply that the existing individual is a stage philosophy sublates.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: ten marks and two demands - the argument and the assessment. One contrast pair, not four, and a ruling in the last two lines.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; target two; argument three; contrasts three; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> target -> argument -> contrasts -> bounded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** existential against logical system; leap against mediation.
- **Evidence:** *Postscript* (1846), by Climacus.
- **Distinction:** exposing a loss against refuting a system.
- **Criticism:** the Hegelian sublation reply.

Solved PYQ 11 · 2023 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." In the light of this statement bring out the chief features of Sartre's conception of consciousness.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"In the light of ... bring out the chief features" - the statement is the organising principle
Core issue	Both halves of the formula, and what they generate
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the contrast, both halves, nihilation, two consequences, one objection
Ideal thesis	Non-self-identity is the definition of the for-itself, and everything else is its application
Non-negotiables	en-soi/pour-soi; both halves; nihilation; bad faith; the useless passion

Independent model answer

Thesis. The formula is a definition, not a paradox: it says that consciousness is constituted by a distance from itself that it can never close.

The contrast. FACT: **Being-in-itself** (*en-soi*) is full, solid, **self-identical** and opaque - "it is what it is" - and contingent, "de trop". **Being-for-itself** (*pour-soi*) is nihilating and self-surpassing, and never coincides with itself.

"Is what it is not." Consciousness is always **ahead of itself**, projecting toward possibilities it does not yet possess; it is defined by a **future** that does not yet exist.

"Is not what it is." Consciousness cannot coincide with its **past** or its **facticity**. Sartre's waiter *is* a waiter in his facticity and *is not* one in his transcendence: he can question the role, resent it, leave it.

How this is possible. FACT: **Nihilation** (*neantisation*): consciousness stands back from what is and negates it - questioning, imagining alternatives, projecting beyond it. The for-itself is "the being by which **nothingness** (*neant*) comes into the world."

What it generates. ANALYSIS: **Freedom**, since nothing in me is fixed enough to determine me; **bad faith**, the attempt to be self-identical anyway by collapsing into facticity or transcendence alone; **ecstatic temporality**, since the for-itself exists as past-facticity and future-project; **being-for-others**, since the Look confers an outside I cannot occupy; and the impossible desire to be a *pour-soi-en-soi*, which is God - hence "man is a **useless passion**".

Objection. CAUTION: Is non-self-identity coherent, or a contradiction in phenomenological dress? The reply is that the for-itself has no completed nature with which to be identical, since it exists as a relation to its own possibilities rather than as a thing with properties; whether that succeeds is contested.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "chief features" invites a list; the statement forbids one. Derive the features from the formula and the answer becomes an argument.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis one line; contrast three; two halves four; nihilation three; consequences four; objection two.

- **Structure:** definition -> contrast -> both halves -> mechanism -> consequences -> objection.
- **Doctrine:** en-soi/pour-soi; nihilation; the impossible synthesis.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Nothingness* (1943); the waiter.
- **Distinction:** future-projection against past-facticity.
- **Criticism:** the coherence of non-self-identity.

Solved PYQ 12 · 2024 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Kierkegaard define truth in terms of subjectivity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does ... define" plus "critically" - definition and ruling in a ten-mark space
Core issue	The <i>how</i> against the <i>what</i> , and the anti-relativist safeguard
Scope boundary	Ten marks: attribution, definition, the denials, complement, verdict
Ideal thesis	Truth here names a mode of appropriation, protected from relativism by its own complement
Non-negotiables	Climacus; appropriation; "subjectivity is untruth"; fideism named

Independent model answer

Thesis. Truth, in this sense, names the **manner** in which an existing individual holds what he holds, not a property that belief confers on propositions.

Attribution. FACT: The thesis belongs to the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus**, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846).

The definition. For **ethical and religious** truth the **mode of appropriation** - infinite passionate inwardness, commitment, risk - is decisive. Knowing that God exists as an item in a system is not existing before God in faith.

Three denials. ANALYSIS: Not relativism; not a denial of objective truth in logic or history, only of its **sufficiency** for existence; not the claim that facts vary with passion.

The safeguard. FACT: Climacus also writes "**subjectivity is untruth**": the existing subject stands in sin and finitude and therefore needs the **leap**. A relativist could make no use of that sentence, which is the internal evidence against the relativist reading.

Critical ruling. CAUTION: The account rightly identifies truths that cannot be held without being lived. It remains exposed to the **fideism** charge, since reason is declared limited rather than corrected, and to the objection that its account of community is thin - and, being pseudonymous, it is deliberately not offered as a doctrine one can simply take over.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the whole answer turns on one distinction; state it in line one and use the remaining space to protect it.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; attribution one; definition three; denials two; safeguard two; ruling three.

- **Structure:** thesis -> attribution -> definition -> denials -> safeguard -> ruling.
- **Doctrine:** the *how* against the *what*.
- **Evidence:** *Postscript* (1846); the pseudonym rule.
- **Distinction:** insufficiency of objective truth against its denial.
- **Criticism:** fideism; the deliberate non-doctrinal form.

Solved PYQ 13 · 2024 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: What do the existentialist thinkers mean by the slogan "existence precedes essence"? How is human existence related to human freedom according to them? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two questions, and the first contains a false presupposition to be corrected while answering
Core issue	That the slogan has one owner, and that "freedom" means three different things
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the argument, the two other positions, three conceptions of freedom, a verdict
Ideal thesis	One slogan, one owner, three refusals of antecedent essence, three conceptions of freedom
Non-negotiables	paper-knife; atheism as premise; 1945/46; the 1946/47 repudiation; Kierkegaard's date

Independent model answer

Thesis. The slogan is **Sartre's**, and the honest answer explains it, then shows that the other two printed thinkers refuse antecedent essence in different ways and mean different things by freedom.

Sartre's argument. FACT: For a manufactured object - the **paper-knife** (*coupe-papier*) - the artisan conceives the design and then produces it, so essence precedes existence; theism treated man analogously. **Atheism is Sartre's premise:** with no divine artisan there is no antecedent blueprint, so man "first of all exists ... and defines himself afterwards". Provenance: the lecture of **October 1945**, published **1946**, not *Being and Nothingness* (1943).

Heidegger. ANALYSIS: In the "**Letter on Humanism**" (written 1946, published **1947**) he **repudiates** the formula. His own sentence - "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence", **Section 9** - is **ontological**: Dasein's "what" is its **manner of being**, not a *quidditas*. Sartre, he charges, merely **reverses** the priority while keeping man at the centre - the **metaphysics of subjectivity**. Man is the "shepherd of Being".

Kierkegaard. FACT: He died in **1855** and never wrote the slogan, and could not accept its premise, since the God-relation is what makes the single individual possible at all. His refusal takes the form of the **existing individual** (*den Enkelte*) who cannot be completed inside a system: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."

Three conceptions of freedom. **Sartre:** freedom is what the for-itself *is* - inescapable, but exercised only in **situation**, since facticity limits practical possibility without converting the for-itself into a thing; hence responsibility, **anguish**, and "in choosing myself I choose man". **Heidegger:** freedom is **thrown projection** upon possibilities disclosed in a world one did not choose, not voluntarism, and authenticity is a formal owning of finitude rather than self-creation. **Kierkegaard:** freedom is **qualitative choice** within a finite God-relation, disclosed in anxiety as "the dizziness of freedom" and consummated in the **leap** that no argument can supply.

Verdict. CAUTION: What the three share is a refusal, not a creed: no general essence settles in advance what it is for this individual to exist. The Sartrean doctrine foregrounds project and responsibility but leaves value-criteria and situated constraint underdeveloped, which is why the charge of decisionism has proved durable.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question presupposes shared ownership. Correct it in the first line *while answering*, rather than complaining about the premise.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; Sartre's argument five; Heidegger four; Kierkegaard three; three freedoms six; verdict two.

- **Structure:** correct the attribution -> the argument -> the two refusals -> three freedoms -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** paper-knife; Section 9; the existing individual.
- **Evidence:** lecture 1945/1946; "Letter on Humanism" 1946/1947; Kierkegaard d. 1855.
- **Distinction:** shared refusal against shared doctrine.
- **Criticism:** decisionism and the thinness of value-criteria.

Solved PYQ 14 · 2025 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the difference between being-for-itself and being-in-itself as presented by Sartre.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the difference" - a clean contrast , with the ontological character stated
Core issue	That the distinction is ontological, not a mind-matter dualism
Scope boundary	Ten marks: two definitions, the formulas, nihilation, the impossible synthesis
Ideal thesis	Self-identity against constitutive non-identity
Non-negotiables	both formulas; "de trop"; nihilation; the <i>pour-soi-en-soi</i>

Independent model answer

Thesis. The distinction is **ontological**, not a division between matter and mind: it separates being that coincides with itself from being that cannot.

Being-in-itself (en-soi). FACT: Full, solid, **self-identical**, opaque: "**it is what it is**". A stone simply *is*. It is complete, non-relational, and **contingent** - "**de trop**", in excess, groundless - which is the ontological root of nausea.

Being-for-itself (pour-soi). Consciousness, which is **nihilating** and self-surpassing and never coincides with itself: "**it is what it is not and is not what it is**". It **is what it is not** because it is defined by a future it does not yet possess; it **is not what it is** because it cannot coincide with its past or facticity.

How the gap is possible. FACT: **Nihilation** (*neantisation*): consciousness stands back from what is and negates it - questioning, imagining alternatives, projecting beyond. The for-itself is "the being by which **nothingness** comes into the world".

The consequence. ANALYSIS: The for-itself perpetually desires to become en-soi while remaining conscious - a **pour-soi-en-soi**, which is God, and a contradiction. Human reality is defined by this impossible desire: "man is a **useless passion**".

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: ten marks reward precision, not coverage; the two formulas and the impossible synthesis are the whole examinable content.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; en-soi three; pour-soi four; nihilation two; consequence two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> in-itself -> for-itself -> mechanism -> consequence.
- **Doctrine:** self-identity; nihilation; the contradictory ideal.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Nothingness* (1943).
- **Distinction:** ontological, not mind-matter.
- **Criticism:** implicit - the coherence of non-self-identity, if space allows.

Six original questions in the style of the paper - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks - covering the parts of the clause the 2018-2025 corpus has not yet examined directly: Kierkegaardian anxiety, the "they" and falling, the Look, indirect communication, the fear/anxiety comparison, and the movement-level objections. Every model answer is independent learner practice.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "Anxiety is the dizziness of freedom." Explain what Kierkegaard means by anxiety and why he distinguishes it from fear.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Anxiety is not an intense fear but an **objectless** disclosure of possibility, and it is the objectlessness that gives it its philosophical role.

The distinction. FACT: **Fear** is directed at a **determinate entity within the world** - a dog, an examination, a fall - and it drives one back toward the world, seeking shelter in the familiar. **Anxiety** (*Angest*), as the pseudonym **Vigilius Haufniensis** analyses it in *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), has no such object: "the object of anxiety is a **nothing**".

What it discloses. Since there is no entity for anxiety to be about, what it discloses cannot be an entity but must be a **structure: possibility**, "the possibility of being able". Hence the formula - anxiety is "the **dizziness of freedom**" - and its description as "a sympathetic antipathy and an antipathetic sympathy".

The example. The man at the edge of an abyss grows dizzy, but **the dizziness is as much in the eye as in the abyss**: what appals is not the drop but the discovery that nothing prevents him.

Its role. ANALYSIS: Anxiety is already present **in innocence**, before any knowledge of good and evil, and is the **presupposition** of the leap by which sin and selfhood enter - not its cause, since a caused leap would not be a leap. ANALYSIS: Lowrie renders *Angest* as "dread" and Hong as "anxiety".

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the whole answer is one distinction, stated in kind rather than degree, and defended by an example.

- **Structure:** thesis -> distinction -> what is disclosed -> example -> role -> translation caution.
- **Doctrine:** objectlessness; possibility; the presupposition of the leap.
- **Evidence:** *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), Vigilius Haufniensis.
- **Distinction:** difference in kind, not intensity.
- **Criticism:** implicit in the caution about translations and attribution.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain Heidegger's notion of *das Man* and show why 'falling' is not a moral failing.

Independent model answer

Thesis. *Das Man* names the impersonal "anyone" in whose name things are done, and falling is the ontological structure of absorption in that anonymity - which is why neither carries blame.

The "they". FACT: Dasein exists with others - **being-with** (*Mitsein*, Section 26) is constitutive, not added on - and tends to lose itself in what "**one**" (*man*) does, says and thinks. ANALYSIS: *Das Man* is not "other people" but the anonymous norm-setter: one reads what one reads, one retires when one retires, and nobody in particular is answerable.

Its three marks. FACT: **Idle talk** (*Gerede*) - passing along received opinions without genuine understanding; **curiosity** (*Neugier*) - flitting restlessly from novelty to novelty; **ambiguity** (*Zweideutigkeit*) - everything seems accessible and nothing is genuinely appropriated. Each is a **deficient mode** of an existentials rather than a vice.

Why falling is not a failing. **Falling** (*Verfallen*) is Dasein's tendency to be absorbed in the world of its concern and in *das Man*. ANALYSIS: It is expressly **not** a theological "fall from grace" but an **ontological structure**: Dasein is inauthentic **proximally and for the most part** (*zunächst und zumeist*), and this is a structural feature of being-in-the-world, not a deficiency to be repented.

Consequence. FACT: Authenticity is therefore a **modification** of this condition, reached through the silent **call of conscience** and **anticipatory resoluteness** - a change in ownership, not in moral quality.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the second clause of the question is the marked point; the exposition must be arranged so that the non-moral verdict is earned rather than announced.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the "they" -> three marks -> why not a failing -> consequence.
- **Doctrine:** *Mitsein*; deficient modes; falling as structure.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Time* (1927) Section 26, 27, 35-38.

- **Distinction:** ontological structure against moral fault.
- **Criticism:** implicit - the formality that makes falling blameless also makes authenticity contentless.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Sartre's claim that conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim follows validly from Sartre's premises, and the premises - above all the exclusivity of subject and object - are where the argument is vulnerable.

How the Other is given. FACT: In the keyhole scene I am absorbed pre-reflectively: there is **no ego** in my consciousness and no self to be ashamed. Footsteps transform this instantly: **I am seen**, and I become an object with a nature, judged from outside. **Shame** is by its structure shame **before someone**, so "shame is by nature **recognition**"; the Other is **lived**, not inferred. Hence "the Other is the **indispensable mediator** between myself and me": I acquire an **outside** I did not choose and cannot know from within.

Why conflict follows. ANALYSIS: Objectified by the Other's freedom, I have two options and both fail. **Assimilating** that freedom - love, language, masochism - fails because to be loved is to be made an object, so the very freedom sought is destroyed in the possessing. **Transcending** it - indifference, desire, sadism, hate - fails because an object cannot confer the recognition wanted, and hate seeks a disappearance that would leave my being-for-others intact. Hence *Huis clos* (1944): "**hell is other people**".

The correction. FACT: Sartre explained in a **1965** recorded preface that the line does not mean relations with others are always poisonous, but that if one's relations are twisted the Other's judgement becomes the medium of self-torment - and that the three characters are **dead**, and so fixed.

Criticism. CAUTION: Three objections. The examples are drawn from a narrow, largely pathological range. Love, trust and being-cared-for seem equally basic and are not objectifications. And **Levinas** argues that to meet the Other only as a rival freedom is still to think him from the self - an objection **unanswered** within *Being and Nothingness*. Sartre's later **group-in-fusion** (1960) suggests the first objection landed.

Verdict. The Look gives a compelling non-inferential account of exposure to another perspective; the leap from that to universal conflict depends on the presupposition that one cannot be looking and looked-at at once.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically examine" requires that the objection attack a **premise**, not merely register discomfort with the conclusion.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the Look -> why conflict -> the correction -> three objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** shame as recognition; the two failing strategies.
- **Evidence:** *Being and Nothingness* (1943) Part III; *Huis clos* (1944); the 1965 preface; the 1960 *Critique*.
- **Distinction:** ontological claim against statistical generalisation.
- **Criticism:** subject/object exclusivity; Levinas unanswered.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "Pseudonymity is the formal counterpart of the doctrine that truth is subjectivity." Discuss.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct: the form is **deduced** from the doctrine, and reading pseudonymity as a literary habit removes an argument.

The argument, in steps. FACT: (i) Objective truth - historical, scientific, metaphysical - can be transmitted **directly**: I state a result, you receive it, and nothing about your existence need change. (ii) Ethical and religious truth is not a result but a **mode of existing**, an appropriation in inwardness. (iii) Communicated directly, it would be taken over **as a result** - as information one can hold without becoming - and the communication would therefore **falsify** what it communicates. (iv) Hence **indirect communication** (*indirekte Meddelelse*): a form that withholds the result and refuses authority. (v) The model is **Socratic maieutics**, the midwife who "**deceives into the truth**", and the author becomes a **vanishing occasion**. (vi) Hence **pseudonymity**: each pseudonym is a **personified existence-possibility** writing from within a sphere it cannot see beyond.

The evidence. FACT: **Johannes de Silentio** admires faith without possessing it; **Johannes Climacus** is explicitly not a Christian, which is why he can pose the problem of becoming one; **Anti-Climacus** stands above Kierkegaard himself. Simultaneously, under his own name, Kierkegaard published the **Upbuilding Discourses** - the **direct pole** of a single strategy. In the "**First and Last Declaration**" (*Postscript*, 1846) he calls himself the "author's author", a **prompter**, and asks that the pseudonym be quoted.

Objections. CAUTION: The method makes his own position **unattributable**; the reply is the signed pole and *The Point of View*, **written 1848, published posthumously 1859** - itself a disputed retrospective. More sharply, if subjective truth cannot be said directly, the thesis cannot be said directly either; **Climacus concedes this** by **revoking** the *Postscript* at its close.

Verdict. The method's **cost** is that it is self-consuming; its **power** is that the cost is intended. Kierkegaard is not evading a position but denying that a position, in Hegel's systematic sense, is the kind of thing an existing individual can hand over.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the six numbered steps are the answer's spine; the pseudonym evidence proves the steps rather than replacing them.

- **Structure:** thesis -> six-step argument -> evidence -> objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** appropriation; maieutics; existence-possibilities.
- **Evidence:** *Postscript* (1846); the "First and Last Declaration"; *The Point of View* (1848/1859).
- **Distinction:** method against biography.
- **Criticism:** unattributability; the revocation.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Anxiety is not a stronger kind of fear." Examine the role of anxiety in Kierkegaard, Heidegger and Sartre, and assess whether a mood can disclose a philosophical truth.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Fear and anxiety differ **in kind**, not degree, and the shared argument in all three thinkers turns on that difference - though the conclusion each draws is different.

The general argument. ANALYSIS: (i) Moods are not private colourings added to a neutral world; they are ways in which one's situation is **disclosed**. (ii) **Fear** discloses an entity as threatening and keeps us within the world of concern. (iii) **Anxiety** has no entity as its object and therefore cannot disclose an entity. (iv) Yet it plainly discloses something, since it has definite content and is not mere confusion. (v) Therefore what it discloses is a **structure**. (vi) Therefore anxiety is philosophically **privileged**: the one mood in which existence as a whole becomes an issue.

Kierkegaard. FACT: *The Concept of Anxiety* (1844), by **Vigilius Haufniensis**: "the object of anxiety is a **nothing**"; what appears is **possibility**, "the possibility of being able". Anxiety is "the **dizziness of freedom**", present already in **innocence**, and the **presupposition** of the leap.

Heidegger. FACT: *Being and Time* **Section 40**: in anxiety "the world has the character of **complete insignificance**" - the totality of involvements collapses and Dasein is thrown back on its bare *that-it-is*. That in the face of which and that for which one is anxious **are the same: being-in-the-world**. Anxiety discloses Dasein as *solus ipse* and **frees it for authentic choosing**. In "What is Metaphysics?" (1929) he adds that it reveals the **Nothing** (*das Nichts*) - "nothing noths", never "noughts".

Sartre. FACT: *Being and Nothingness* (1943), Part I. On the **cliff path** I feel fear of the drop, then realise that **nothing prevents me** from throwing myself over - vertigo before my own freedom. The **gambler** finds yesterday's firm resolution **present but powerless**: it must be remade now, and nothing guarantees he will remake it. ANALYSIS: Anguish is distinct from **nausea**, which discloses the contingency of the in-itself.

Assessment. CAUTION: The naturalist replies that anxiety is a clinical or neurochemical state with no cognitive credentials. The counter is that the existentialist claim is not that anxious people know more, but that the **structure** of the mood - having no object - is itself the datum requiring explanation, and no reduction of it to an unnoticed object has succeeded. **Verdict:** a mood can disclose a structure without becoming infallible cognition; naturalistic and clinical explanations remain compatible competitors rather than refuted rivals, and the three analyses must not be merged

into one mood theory.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the six-step argument makes the three expositions cumulative rather than parallel; without it the answer becomes three summaries.

- **Structure:** thesis -> shared argument -> three analyses -> naturalist objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** objectlessness; possibility, being-in-the-world, freedom.
- **Evidence:** *Concept of Anxiety* (1844); *Being and Time* Section 40; "What is Metaphysics?" (1929); the cliff path and the gambler.
- **Distinction:** difference in kind; anguish against nausea.
- **Criticism:** the naturalist competitor, met but not defeated.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Existentialism has been charged with subjectivism, pessimism and social abstraction. Examine these charges with reference to Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Each charge has a different answer for each thinker, so a single reply on behalf of "existentialism" would answer for none of them; two of the three charges fail as stated, and the third partly succeeds.

Why the charges must be split. ANALYSIS: "Existentialism" is a retrospective family label: Kierkegaard died in **1855** and never met the word, Heidegger denied it in the "Letter on Humanism" (**1946/47**), and only Sartre accepted and defined it (**1945/46**). A movement-level objection is therefore a shape awaiting three different fillings.

Subjectivism. CAUTION: Against **Kierkegaard** the charge misfires: Climacus's thesis concerns the **mode of appropriation**, not the content of belief, and the same author writes "**subjectivity is untruth**", which no relativist could use. Against **Sartre** it misfires differently: choice is bound to **responsibility** and to "in choosing myself, I choose man". Against **Heidegger** it misfires most clearly: he is conducting **fundamental ontology**, and *das Man* is criticised precisely for validating received opinion. FACT: The charge fails as stated.

Pessimism. CAUTION: Anxiety, despair, death and nothingness are **diagnostic and disclosive structures**, not the claim that every life is emotionally miserable. Kierkegaard's despair is a **misrelation** that may be entirely unfelt; Heidegger's being-toward-death is a **possibility** that individualises rather than a morbid preoccupation; Sartre's anguish is the recognition of freedom. FACT: The charge rests on reading technical terms as mood-reports.

Social abstraction. ANALYSIS: Here the critics land a blow. Sartre's early vocabulary under-describes gendered, racialised and material constraint - pressed by **de Beauvoir**, **Fanon** and Marxist critics - and his own *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960), with **scarcity**, **seriality** and the **practico-inert**, concedes it. Heidegger's **being-with** (Section 26) is constitutive, but authenticity remains **formally empty**, a charge sharpened by his 1933 complicity and by Adorno's "jargon of authenticity". Kierkegaard's treatment of institutions and community is genuinely thin, and "the crowd is untruth" answers only part of the objection.

Verdict. CAUTION: Subjectivism and pessimism are misdescriptions that dissolve once the technical vocabulary is respected. Social abstraction is a **real residue**: the replies available - situated freedom, being-with, and the individual's irreducible responsibility - are **partial rather than complete**, and the honest closing move is to concede that rather than to argue it away.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the structure - one charge, three replies, then a ruling - is what converts a survey into an examination, and the concession at the end is what makes the earlier defences credible.

- **Structure:** thesis -> why split the charges -> three charges, three replies each -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** appropriation; responsibility; fundamental ontology; disclosive moods.
- **Evidence:** *Postscript* (1846); "Letter on Humanism" (1946/47); *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960); Section 26.
- **Distinction:** misdescription against genuine residue.
- **Criticism:** formal emptiness; thin community; partial replies conceded.